

Tacere: Disclosure as a Governance Decision in Professional Environments

Abstract

Existing workplace frameworks addressing disclosure, accommodation, and retention assume that non-disclosure reflects a gap in psychological safety, legal literacy, or organizational support. This paper argues that assumption is structurally incomplete.

It introduces Tacere: the sustained, strategic practice of keeping one's own counsel by a senior executive operating in a professional environment where disclosure carries professional risk. Tacere is not a failure condition. It is a governance decision made in response to an incentive structure in which visibility carries cost and concealment remains an option.

The paper distinguishes Tacere from adjacent constructs including *impression management*, *identity concealment*, *covering*, *coping*, and *strategic ambiguity*. Unlike these frameworks, Tacere operates prior to and independently of any organizational relationship. It does not require an audience, a stigmatized identity, or a distress condition. It requires only the individual's assessment of professional risk.

The paper demonstrates that professional environments produce Tacere through the interaction of incentive and opportunity structures, without requiring organizational intent. It further argues that for Black and African American women, the cost structure of visibility is historically compounded, making race a foundational condition of the decision environment rather than a moderating variable.

The framework has implications for organizational governance, retention risk, and workplace policy design. Systems that require disclosure to activate systematically exclude the population most affected by it. The paper introduces Disclosure-Independent Performance ProtectionSM as a conceptual design constraint for support architectures that must function in the presence of Tacere rather than in opposition to it.

I. Introduction

Workplace frameworks addressing disclosure, accommodation, and retention share a foundational assumption: that the decision to not disclose a health condition, a caregiving obligation, or a limitation on her availability, reflects a gap in organizational conditions. The dominant explanations are familiar. Psychological safety is insufficient. Legal pathways are unclear. Support infrastructure is inadequate or inaccessible. Logic says: improve the conditions, and disclosure will follow.

This paper argues that assumption is structurally incomplete.

The individual who assessed organizational conditions accurately, weighed the professional cost of transparency against the cost of concealment, and decided that disclosure is not rational in her current environment is not experiencing a gap in psychological safety. She is exercising a governance function. She is making a calculated determination about information asymmetry, in a professional environment where the incentive structure makes transparency costly, and concealment viable. That determination may persist across years, across roles, and across organizations. It may operate entirely in the absence of distress. It may coexist with full professional performance, strong performance reviews, and organizational recognition as a top performer. None of those conditions change the calculation. They may reinforce it.

This paper introduces Tacere as a conceptual framework naming that condition. Tacere is defined as the sustained, strategic practice of keeping one's own counsel by a senior executive operating in a professional environment where disclosure carries professional risk. The framework classifies Tacere as a distinct subject of study within organizational behavior, labor economics, and employment law, and argues that its absence from the existing literature constitutes a structural gap with material consequences for organizational governance, retention risk, and workplace policy design.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section II reviews how disclosure is treated across three bodies of existing literature as a foundational assumption and identifies the classification gap that Tacere addresses. Section III defines the framework and distinguishes it from adjacent constructs with which it may be confused. Section IV examines the incentive and opportunity structure that produces Tacere as a predictable organizational outcome. Section V addresses the intersectional dimension of the framework, arguing that for Black and African American women in professional

environments, the calculation that produces Tacere carries a historical and structural weight that makes race a foundational condition of the framework rather than a moderating variable. Section VI introduces Disclosure-Independent Performance ProtectionSM as the structural response architecture designed to operate in the presence of Tacere. Section VII draws implications for organizational governance, retention risk, and workplace policy design, drawing on documented behavioral data that confirms those patterns. Section VIII addresses limitations. Section IX concludes.

This paper is the individual behavioral complement to a companion conceptual framework, Invisible AttritionSM: A Conceptual Framework for Leadership Capacity Erosion Prior to Organizational Detection, which addresses the organizational measurement consequences of the same structural condition. Together the two frameworks propose that Tacere and Invisible AttritionSM are two observations of the same incentive structure from two different positions: the individual who has decided not to disclose her condition, and the organization that has no instrument to detect the retention risk that her decision is creating. The contribution of both papers is classification. Classification produces the conditions for infrastructure design that does not require disclosure as a precondition for support. The response architecture introduced in Section VI, Disclosure-Independent Performance ProtectionSM, is presented as a conceptual design constraint derived from the classification developed in this paper, not as an operational model or commercial offering.

II. Disclosure as Foundational Assumption: A Review of Three Literatures

These frameworks share a foundational assumption: that disclosure is what activates support, protection, and intervention. The woman who has not disclosed is not a failure of the framework. She is simply outside it. The framework was never designed to reach her, and the data it generates will never reflect her presence because the collection condition requires an act she has not taken.

Accommodation and Employment Law Frameworks

The Americans with Disabilities Act, state-level workplace protection statutes, and the expanding body of menopause, chronic illness, and caregiver status legislation that has emerged across more than twenty states since 2024 all require disclosure as the initiating condition for protection. The architecture is consistent regardless of the specific

statutory framework: accommodation frameworks activate when a request is filed, clinical pathways open when a condition is named, workplace protections apply when a disclosure is made, and benefit programs respond when an individual self-identifies. The support activates when the record exists. Without the record, the system has nothing to act on.

The literature within this domain addresses barriers to disclosure with increasing sophistication. Stigma, fear of professional consequence, lack of legal literacy, and inadequate manager training are documented findings. The policy response has followed: awareness campaigns, manager education, anti-discrimination provisions, and accommodation mandates designed to reduce the cost of disclosure and increase the likelihood that individuals will engage with available protections.

What the accommodation and employment law literature does not address is the individual who has assessed the available protections, understood the statutory landscape, and determined that disclosure remains professionally untenable regardless of what the law permits. The barrier literature treats non-disclosure as a response to insufficient conditions. It does not classify the sustained strategic practice that operates when the individual has assessed the conditions and found them insufficient, not through ignorance of what is available, but through accurate assessment of what disclosure would cost her in the specific professional environment she navigates.

Psychological Safety Research

The psychological safety literature, developed most influentially through Edmondson's (1999) foundational work and extended across organizational behavior, team dynamics, and human resource management research, treats non-disclosure as evidence of insufficient psychological safety within an organizational context. The measurement instrument is the perception of interpersonal risk: whether an individual believes she can speak up, surface a problem, or disclose a need without fear of negative consequence. The prescription is organizational: improve the conditions, train the managers, signal from leadership that disclosure is safe.

This framework has produced significant and valuable research on the organizational conditions that enable or suppress voice behavior. However, its limitation for the purposes of this paper is structural rather than methodological. The psychological safety framework treats the organizational environment as the independent variable and individual disclosure behavior as the dependent variable. It does not account for the individual who has accurately assessed the organizational environment, concluded that

the environment is safe enough in general, but not safe enough for this specific disclosure. She decided with the full weight of that knowledge, that the cost of becoming visible and risking her credibility and authority, exceeds the value of the benefit. That executive is not experiencing low psychological safety in the sense the literature measures. She is making a governance decision the framework was not designed to capture.

The deeper limitation is that the psychological safety framework treats visibility as a neutral state that is either enabled or suppressed by organizational conditions. But it does not account for the structural reality that visibility is not neutral. It carries professional cost in both directions: surfaced through disclosure and accumulated through concealment. Improving organizational conditions for disclosure changes one variable in the individual's calculation, without neutralizing the cost of becoming visible in an environment where visibility itself carries professional risk. The woman who discloses, and the woman who does not, may both be responding rationally to the same environment. The psychological safety framework has instruments for one of them.

Retention and Attrition Research

The retention and attrition literature classifies voluntary departure as the terminal event and works backward from exit data to identify predictive indicators. Engagement surveys, performance trajectories, manager relationship quality, and compensation competitiveness are the dominant instruments. The logic is detection: identify the signals that precede departure and intervene before the exit occurs.

This framework cannot detect what was never created. When a senior professional departs following years of sustained high performance, without prior accommodation requests, without clinical engagement that produced an organizational record, and without any disclosed health or capacity condition, the departure registers as voluntary. The exit interview, if one occurs, produces a stated reason, and the record reflects full performance until it reflects departure, with nothing in between. The measurement instruments record the exit. They do not record what accumulated before it.

This is not a data quality problem. It is a structural condition of how the data is generated. Attrition instruments are calibrated to detect declining performance, disengagement, and the behavioral signals that precede voluntary departure in the general population. They are not calibrated to detect the accumulated cost of sustained non-disclosure in a senior executive, whose performance record provides no prior signal

of risk. The departure arrives without warning, because the warning was the signal she decided to not give.

The Classification Gap

Across all three bodies of literature, the sustained strategic practice of keeping one's own counsel in a professional environment where disclosure carries professional risk, is treated as the unexplained residue. The portion of non-disclosure behavior that the barrier literature cannot account for, the individual whose departure the retention instruments did not predict, the employee whose psychological safety assessment would have registered as positive while her disclosure decision remained unchanged. None of these literatures names the practice itself as a subject of study. The contribution of this paper is to do so, and the framework that follows establishes the classification those literatures have not produced.

III. Tacere: Definition, Behavioral Mechanics, and Distinguishing the Framework

Definition

Tacere is defined as the sustained, strategic practice of keeping one's own counsel by a senior executive operating in a professional environment where disclosure carries professional risk. The term draws from the Latin *tacere*, to be silent, to withhold, to leave unmentioned. The Latin carries a precise implication that the English word *silent* does not: *tacere* is not the silence in the absence of analysis. It is the silence of decision. The individual practicing Tacere has something to say. But she has decided not to say it.

The definition has three components, each of which is analytically necessary and none of which is reducible to the others.

Sustained

Tacere is not a single decision but a practice maintained over time, often across years, requiring continuous recalibration as the professional environment shifts. The individual does not make one disclosure decision at the onset of a health condition and carry it unchanged across years, roles, and organizational contexts. She reassesses at each inflection point, before the performance review, before the promotion cycle, before the reorganization, before the new manager arrives, because each shift in the environment

updates the calculus. The practice is active rather than passive, requiring ongoing attention to the incentive structure and ongoing management of the gap between what she is carrying and what the organization sees.

This is a critical distinction from a one-time disclosure decision. A woman who declines to disclose a health condition at the time of diagnosis and then continues in her role without revisiting that decision is not practicing Tacere in the full sense of the framework. Tacere describes the sustained governance of that decision across a professional tenure, with changing conditions requiring continual recalibration.

Strategic

The practice is calculated, not reactive. It reflects an ongoing assessment of the incentive structure and the professional cost of transparency at each decision point. Although she may have researched the legal framework thoroughly and may operate in an organization with robust wellness infrastructure, menopause benefits, FMLA protections, ADA accommodations, and stated commitments to psychological safety, she continues to keep her own counsel because her assessment of the specific professional cost in her specific context has led her to a different conclusion.

The strategic dimension also means that Tacere is responsive to professional context in ways that other frameworks do not account for. The same individual may practice Tacere in one professional environment and choose disclosure in another. The condition being managed did not change, the incentive structure did.

Keeping One's Own Counsel

The third component is the most important for distinguishing the framework from adjacent constructs. The individual practicing Tacere is not withholding from the organization. She is governing her own information in an environment she has assessed as unable to receive it safely, which is a meaningfully different act. Keeping one's own counsel means holding one's opinions, intentions, and assessments privately, trusting one's own judgment, rather than submitting it to external systems that may not be equipped to process it without consequence. The sovereignty belongs to her. The organization is not party to a decision the individual made about her own situation, in her own best interest, and that distinction prevents the misclassification of Tacere as deception, concealment, or a failure of organizational transparency. She is neither lying, nor is she hiding. She is keeping her own counsel, which is the exercise of a governance function over her own information in an environment where the cost structure makes that exercise rational and necessary.

Distinguishing Tacere from Adjacent Constructs

Five constructs in the existing literature are close enough to Tacere to require a clear distinction. Each shares common ground but breaks from the framework on salient dimensions.

Impression management (Goffman, 1959) describes the active, ongoing shaping of how one is perceived by others in a social or professional context. It is relational and audience-dependent: it operates in the space between the individual and the audience she is performing for. Tacere operates prior to that space. It does not require an audience. The decision is made before any organizational communication occurs. The organization is never a party to the calculation.

Identity concealment describes the active hiding of a stigmatized identity from others who might respond negatively to its disclosure. The foundational framework here is Goffman's (1963) category of the discreditable identity: a stigma that is unknown and can be concealed, leading the individual to pass as normal to avoid social exclusion. Tacere is not passing and does not require a stigmatized identity. It requires a professional environment where disclosure carries professional cost. The condition being governed may be entirely non-stigmatized in other contexts, fully accepted in clinical and social environments, and still subject to Tacere in a specific professional environment where its disclosure would alter the individual's professional standing. The mechanism is professional risk, not stigma. That distinction is the one that matters: Goffman's concealment framework assumes the individual is managing a discrediting attribute in relation to social norms. Tacere assumes the individual is making a governance decision about information asymmetry, in a professional environment where the incentive structure makes disclosure costly, regardless of whether the condition carries social stigma.

This does not mean Tacere operates in the absence of stigma. Professional environments attach stigmatizing weight to perceived weakness and to conditions that signal diminished authority or unreliability. What distinguishes Tacere from *identity concealment* is not the absence of stigma but the nature of what is being protected. Goffman's framework governs social acceptance. Tacere governs professional viability. The threat being managed is not social exclusion. It is the erosion of authority. Even a condition that carries no social shame and is fully accepted in clinical and cultural contexts will trigger Tacere if its disclosure would re-categorize the executive as someone whose authority is now conditional rather than assumed.

Covering (Yoshino, 2006) describes the downplaying of a known identity to reduce its salience and assimilate more fully into a dominant organizational culture. It assumes the organization is already aware of the characteristic and the individual is managing how prominently it registers. Tacere operates at an earlier point entirely, before the identity is known to anyone in the professional context, which means there is nothing to downplay because nothing has been disclosed. The organizational relationship that *covering* navigates does not yet exist in Tacere.

Coping describes a reactive, distress-dependent response to a stressor, oriented toward managing the psychological or physiological effects of that stressor. Coping is triggered by the presence of a condition that produces distress. Tacere may operate entirely in the absence of distress. A senior executive practicing Tacere is not managing distress. She is making a governance decision about information asymmetry. The distinction matters because the coping literature and the organizational wellness literature that draws on it produce prescriptions oriented toward distress reduction and psychological support. Those prescriptions do not address the individual who is not in distress, who is performing at the highest level, and for whom the professional cost calculation rather than any psychological state is the operative condition.

Strategic ambiguity describes the deliberate use of language that carries more than one possible meaning within an organizational relationship, preserving interpretive flexibility. Strategic ambiguity is about what is said within a relationship that already exists. Tacere operates prior to and independently of any organizational communication. The individual practicing Tacere is not communicating ambiguously about her condition. She is not communicating about it at all. The organizational relationship that strategic ambiguity navigates does not reach the level at which Tacere operates.

What each of those constructs shares, and what distinguishes all of them from Tacere, is a relationship to an audience or a social environment. The correct classification is governance. Tacere is a governance decision about information asymmetry in a professional environment where the incentive structure makes transparency costly and concealment rational. It is not a social performance, a *coping* response, or a communication strategy. It is the exercise of a sovereign function over one's own information in an environment that has been assessed as unable to receive it safely. That classification is precise for both organizational behavior researchers and legal scholars: it names the decision correctly, locates it prior to any organizational communication, and explains why it persists without needing to assign blame to the organization or deficit to the individual.

IV. The Incentive and Opportunity Structure

The professional environment does not produce Tacere by accident, by failure, or by design flaw. It produces Tacere because it contains the two structural conditions sufficient to make sustained non-disclosure the rational choice for a specific population of senior executives: an incentive structure that makes disclosure costly, and an opportunity structure that makes concealment viable. Neither condition requires organizational intent. Neither requires malice. Neither requires that the organization be indifferent to the individual's wellbeing. An organization can invest genuinely and substantially in wellness infrastructure, accommodation pathways, and psychological safety programming and still produce Tacere as a predictable outcome, because the incentive and opportunity structure operates beneath those investments.

This is the governing logic of the framework: systems do not require intent, they require incentive and opportunity.

Visibility Is Not a Neutral State

The psychological safety literature treats visibility as a condition that is either enabled or suppressed by organizational conditions. Improve the conditions, reduce interpersonal risk, signal from leadership that disclosure is safe, and the individual will disclose what she has been carrying. The prescription is organizational, because the framing is organizational: low visibility is a symptom of insufficient safety.

This paper argues that framing is structurally incomplete. Visibility is not a neutral state that organizational conditions either produce or suppress. It is a state that carries professional cost in both directions, and those costs are not symmetrical. Disclosing a health condition, a caregiving obligation, or a limitation on her availability produces visibility of a specific kind, one in which the executive is now seen as someone whose authority may be in question. In these environments, that perception is not neutral, because it alters how authority is read, how career trajectory is assessed, and how the individual is positioned in the informal systems that govern promotion, assignment, and organizational standing. That cost does not disappear when organizational conditions for psychological safety improve. It may be reduced, but it is not eliminated, and the individual's calculation accounts for the residual.

Concealment carries cost as well, though accumulated rather than immediate. The individual who does not disclose does not eliminate the professional risk of her condition. She redistributes it, absorbing the cost of managing her condition without organizational support, without clinical engagement that might produce a record, and without adjustment to the demands placed on her. The cost accumulates without generating the record that it is accumulating, so that from the outside the record shows sustained performance while from the inside the conditions sustaining that performance are eroding. That asymmetry between the visible record and the invisible cost is the structural condition the retention literature cannot detect and the psychological safety literature was not designed to address.

The distribution of that cost is not equal across populations or professional contexts, and the residual cost of visibility is higher in some environments than others for reasons that are structural and documented rather than incidental. Section V addresses the population for whom that asymmetry is most pronounced. The point here is architectural: the cost structure explains why improving organizational conditions for disclosure changes one variable in the individual's calculation, without resolving the calculation.

The Structural Condition Persists Even When Disclosure Occurs

A critical feature of the incentive and opportunity structure is that it does not resolve when disclosure occurs. A framework that allows a leader to continue delivering at full capacity while deferring the cost of caring for her health does not eliminate the structural condition. The cost does not disappear. Instead it compounds, accumulating in the body she is not treating, in the appointments she is not making, in the rest she is not taking, and in the gap between what the role demands and what she can sustainably produce. The organization recognizes her presence and her output. It does not create or provide the conditions required to sustain both, and the woman who has disclosed but received no meaningful adjustment to her load carries the same invisible accumulation as the woman who said nothing. The record in both cases shows sustained performance. What it does not show is what that performance is costing.

This means the choice between disclosure and non-disclosure, which the psychological safety literature and the accommodation law framework both treat as the operative decision point, is not the determinative variable the existing literature assumes it to be. The structural condition operates on both sides of the disclosure decision. Tacere names the sustained practice on one side. The illustrative case comparison below demonstrates that the structural cost operates on both.

Illustrative Case Comparison

The following comparison is offered as structural demonstration, not empirical testing. It is included to show the incentive and opportunity structure operating in a documented organizational context, not to establish generalizable proof.

In early 2026, two senior women executives at the same major technology company departed for health reasons within the same month. Both had disclosed their conditions. Both had continued working through treatment. Both eventually reached their limits. Both described, in their own words, having deprioritized their own health for the role. The disclosure variable, in both cases, was present. The structural cost was not reduced.

The first was diagnosed with late-stage breast cancer weeks after joining the organization. She disclosed it publicly. She underwent thirteen rounds of chemotherapy while continuing to lead her team. She took a three-month medical leave for treatment and returned. Then, more than a year later, she stepped down permanently. Her own words: she had done everything possible to avoid it, had led through intense cancer treatment because she did not want to step away, and had reached her limits. The organization's response was described as extraordinary. The coverage called her courageous. The disclosure was received within a cultural and medical framework that recognized her condition, named it, and attached a narrative of survivorship to it.

The second disclosed a neuroimmune condition when she joined. For her entire tenure she postponed medical tests and new therapies to stay focused on the role and not miss a single day of work. She took medical leave only when it became unavoidable. Her condition, postural orthostatic tachycardia syndrome, is chronic, functional, and invisible. It carries no cultural recognition infrastructure, no organized advocacy, no prestige narrative. The disclosure did not generate the same reception. What it generated was a second obligation: to perform well enough that the disclosure would not define her. She absorbed that obligation into her body until her body stopped cooperating.

Both women were at the same organization with the same stated commitment to support. Both disclosed. Both worked through their conditions past the point of sustainability. Both departed within the same month. The disclosure variable did not differentiate their outcomes. What differentiated their experience was the prestige hierarchy of the conditions they disclosed. The existing literature on disease prestige

documents that conditions are ranked by the medical establishment according to visibility, organ location, treatment availability, and the social attributes of the patient population (Norredam and Album, 2007). That hierarchy does not stay in the clinic. It enters the professional environment with the disclosure and shapes how the disclosure is received, which narrative it activates, and what the individual is then required to perform to manage the reception.

That they made different decisions about when and how to disclose, and that both still reached the same structural outcome, is evidence of what Tacere describes at its foundation: the calculation is individual, shaped by each woman's specific assessment of what disclosure would cost her in her specific professional position. For the woman whose condition carried cultural recognition, disclosure activated support and a survivorship narrative she then had to sustain through performance. For the woman whose condition carried no such recognition, disclosure activated an obligation to erase its professional implications through work. Both calculations were rational responses to the same incentive structure. Both cost them their health. The organization did not produce this outcome through indifference or malice. It produced it because in organizational environments, disclosure does not eliminate the cost of visibility. It relocates it. And the location it relocates to is shaped by a hierarchy the organization did not create and cannot easily dismantle.

The Power User TrapSM

The opportunity structure that makes Tacere viable is not random. It is created and sustained by her own performance record. The stronger her output, the less the organization is designed to question whether she needs support. The more consistently she delivers, the more the system reads her performance as evidence that nothing is wrong. Her record does not just protect her professionally. It makes keeping her own counsel structurally possible.

Competitive corporate environments produce a specific and predictable dynamic in which the executive whose performance is highest is simultaneously the executive whose need for support is most invisible to the systems responsible for providing it. The Power User TrapSM describes this dynamic: the executive whose output registers as evidence that no support is needed is the executive for whom the existing protection architecture is least accessible. The performance record that makes her indispensable also makes her invisible to the protective instruments calibrated to detect declining performance as the signal for intervention.

The Power User TrapSM does not require that the organization intend to exclude its top talent from protection. It requires only that the protection architecture be calibrated to the signal of need that senior executives are least likely to generate. Accommodation frameworks activate when requests are filed, wellness programs respond when employees engage, and clinical pathways open when conditions are named. The senior executive who has assessed the professional cost of generating any of those signals and decided the cost is untenable will generate none of them. Her performance record will confirm, to every available instrument, that she is fine.

The Governing Logic

The incentive and opportunity structure that produces Tacere is not a pathology of any particular organization, industry, or professional culture. It is a predictable feature of environments in which performance is continuous, visibility carries professional consequence, and the cost of being seen as someone whose authority is in question will often outweigh the benefit of asking for help. Those conditions are present, in varying degrees, across legal practice, financial services, technology, executive leadership, and the full range of professional environments in which the population this framework describes operates.

Systems do not require intent. They require incentive and opportunity. The incentive structure makes disclosure costly, and the opportunity structure makes concealment viable. When the incentive structure makes disclosure costly and the opportunity structure makes concealment viable, and she has done the analysis, Tacere is the decision that follows.

V. The Intersectional Dimension

The existing literature on workplace disclosure treats race as a moderating variable: a factor that influences the degree or frequency of an already-described behavior. Studies find that women of color disclose at lower rates than white women, experience higher levels of anticipated stigma, and report greater fear of professional consequence when considering disclosure. The prescription that follows is consistent with the broader framework: reduce stigma, improve organizational conditions, and disclosure rates across populations will converge.

This paper argues that framing is analytically insufficient for this framework. For Black and African American women in professional environments, race is not a moderating variable that adjusts the degree of Tacere. It is a foundational condition of the calculation itself. This claim is structural in nature and does not assert universality across all professional contexts. The mechanism by which the professional environment produces Tacere is not identical across populations. For Black women, the cost structure of visibility is historically documented, structurally compounded, and not symmetrical with the cost experienced by other populations. That asymmetry is not incidental to the framework. It is foundational to it.

Visibility and the Historical Cost Structure

The argument in Section IV established that visibility is not a neutral state. It carries professional cost in both directions. The distribution of that cost is not equal across populations or professional contexts. For Black women in professional environments, becoming visible as someone whose authority may be in question does not produce the same outcome as it does for other populations. The existing literature documents the pattern: visibility has historically produced scrutiny before support, suspicion before accommodation, and confirmation of a pre-existing narrative before recognition of a legitimate need (Giddings, 1984). Research on Black women in leadership positions confirms that they are held to different and higher standards than white women and leaders of other racial identities, often lack the support that white peers have access to, and are frequently centered in leadership during periods of crisis or organizational scrutiny while being denied full institutional support — a pattern described as the *Glass Cliff Effect* (Ely and Mayo, 2024). The excess mental and emotional labor this produces, including the need to manage credibility, authority, and visibility simultaneously, is documented across professional contexts and represents a specific and compounded cost structure that other populations do not carry (Ely and Mayo, 2024).

This is not a claim about individual organizations, individual managers, or individual acts of discrimination. It is a structural observation about the accumulated weight of a documented historical pattern that enters the professional relationship before the individual arrives in any given organization and operates inside it regardless of that organization's stated commitments. The decision-maker navigating the disclosure calculation in a professional environment is not calculating against a neutral baseline. She is calculating against a baseline that has been shaped by a history she carries with her, that she has assessed accurately, and that organizational improvements have not resolved.

The calculation is not paranoia. It is pattern recognition grounded in documented experience. The distinction matters for the framework because it explains why the standard prescription, "improve organizational conditions and disclosure will follow," fails with particular predictability for this population. The organizational conditions may improve. However, the historical cost structure does not resolve because of organizational policy changes. It is not located in the organization's current policy. It is located in the professional environment as a structural inheritance that precedes it.

The Strong Black Woman Construct as Survival Architecture

The existing literature on the *strong Black woman construct* has addressed it primarily as a psychological phenomenon: a set of beliefs and behaviors associated with self-reliance, emotional suppression, and the resistance to help-seeking. That framing locates the construct inside the individual and treats it as a psychological pattern with health consequences.

This paper reframes it. The strong Black woman construct is not a personality trait or a psychological pattern. It is a survival architecture, externally imposed and internally maintained, predating the professional relationship and operating inside it. It is the behavioral and cognitive infrastructure developed in response to a structural environment that has historically made vulnerability costly and self-sufficiency necessary. The individual who maintains it in a professional context is not expressing a cultural value or a personality characteristic. She is deploying a governance structure that was built for an environment that has not changed sufficiently to make the structure unnecessary.

The consequence for this framework is direct. The strong Black woman construct, understood as survival architecture rather than psychology, compounds the cost of disclosure in a specific and analytically important way. It does not merely add an additional barrier to disclosure. It makes the practice of Tacere structurally reinforced from two directions simultaneously: the professional environment provides the incentive and opportunity conditions that produce Tacere for the general population, and the survival architecture compounds the individual cost of departing from the practice even when the professional environment signals that departure might be safe. Those two reinforcing conditions are not equivalent in their effect. Their interaction is what makes the intersectional dimension of this framework foundational rather than additive.

The Foundational Claim

The argument here is not that Black women experience Tacere differently in degree. It is that the structural conditions that produce Tacere operate differently for Black women in kind. The calculation is made under different conditions, against a different baseline, with a different distribution of cost. A framework that treats those conditions as equivalent to those experienced by other populations will misclassify the condition it is attempting to describe.

The existing literature's treatment of race as a moderating variable produces a specific analytical error: it assumes the underlying mechanism is the same across populations and race adjusts the output. Although that assumption produces useful comparative findings within its own frame, this paper argues the underlying mechanism is not the same. For Black women, the professional cost of visibility is historically compounded, the survival architecture compounds the cost of departing from non-disclosure, and the interaction of those two conditions produces a version of Tacere that is different in kind, not just in degree.

Any framework that requires disclosure to function will fail the women for whom disclosure carries the highest cost. That is not a peripheral observation about a subset of the population this framework describes. It is a design constraint that must be incorporated into the framework's foundational logic. A structural response architecture that does not account for the foundational role of race in the disclosure calculation will reproduce the same gap in reach that characterizes every existing support framework this paper has examined.

VI. Disclosure-Independent Performance ProtectionSM

The frameworks this paper has examined share a common architectural feature: they are designed to activate in response to a disclosed condition. The individual discloses her need, the system receives it, and the support begins. That architecture is not a design flaw. It is the logical expression of how organizational systems are built to function: around records, requests, and the formal initiation of a support relationship. The problem this paper has documented is not that those systems are poorly designed for the population they reach. It is that the population they are designed to reach is not

the population for whom the structural condition this paper describes is most consequential.

Disclosure-Independent Performance ProtectionSM is introduced here as a conceptual category describing a structural response architecture with a different foundational requirement. This is a classification of design constraints, not a programmatic model. It does not require disclosure as an initiating condition. It does not activate in response to a disclosed need. It does not generate a record within any organizational system that carries professional risk for the individual it serves. It is built to operate in the presence of Tacere rather than in opposition to it.

Foundational Design Principles

A structural response architecture designed to function in the presence of Tacere must satisfy two foundational conditions that existing support frameworks do not.

The first is disclosure independence. The framework must produce value without requiring the individual to name her condition, disclose her need, or generate any record that enters an organizational system she did not choose. This is not a privacy feature appended to an existing support model. It is a foundational architectural requirement. Any framework that requires disclosure to function will fail the population for whom disclosure carries the highest cost. Disclosure independence is not a benefit. It is a design constraint.

The second is asset orientation. The framework treats the individual's professional role, compensation trajectory, authority, and standing as assets worth defending rather than as organizational outputs to be managed. The existing support architecture is designed around the organization's interest in sustaining the individual's performance.

Disclosure-Independent Performance ProtectionSM, however, is designed around the individual's interest in protecting her influence and her position within systems she is actively shaping but does not yet fully command. Those are related but not equivalent orientations, and the difference has material consequences for what the framework is designed to do and what it prioritizes when the two interests diverge.

The Relationship to Tacere

Disclosure-Independent Performance ProtectionSM is not a correction to Tacere. It is not designed to reduce the incidence of Tacere, encourage disclosure, or produce a different individual decision. It is designed to operate in the presence of the decision the individual has already made.

The framework accepts the governance decision as given. The individual has assessed the incentive structure, calculated the cost of transparency, and determined that keeping her own counsel is the rational choice in her current professional environment. That determination may be temporary or permanent, context-specific or career-spanning. The framework does not adjudicate it. It builds support infrastructure around it.

This design principle is the architectural expression of the paper's foundational claim: Tacere is not the absence of analysis. It is the product of it. A response architecture built for that individual must begin from the premise that her decision is rational, that the environment that produced it has not changed, and that support which requires her to revise that decision before it activates is not, in any functionally meaningful sense, available to her.

What the Architecture Requires

The conceptual category introduced here has implications for how support infrastructure for women navigating these environments is designed, evaluated, and measured. A framework that does not require disclosure as an initiating condition must develop alternative instruments for assessing need, building a protective strategy, and measuring outcomes that do not depend on the individual disclosing her condition to any organizational system.

It must also account for the compounded structural conditions Section V identified. A response architecture that is disclosure-independent in design, but operationally accessible only to women in professional environments where the cost of seeking any external support is low, will reproduce the same asymmetry in reach that characterizes the frameworks it is designed to supplement. Disclosure independence as a design principle must be implemented in a way that reaches the full population for whom disclosure carries professional risk, including the population for whom that risk is historically compounded, and structurally reinforced from multiple directions simultaneously.

The paper does not specify the operational implementation of this architecture. That is a matter of practice design rather than conceptual framework. What the paper establishes is the design constraint: any support infrastructure that requires disclosure as a precondition for activation cannot reach the population this framework describes. The response must be built differently.

Any operational implementation consistent with this framework would not be defined by its specific features, but by the conditions it satisfies. It would generate protective value without requiring disclosure, operate without producing a record within organizational systems that carry professional consequence, and remain accessible under the same conditions that make disclosure untenable. These are not design preferences. They are structural requirements. A system that fails to meet them, regardless of its stated intent or level of investment, will not reach the population this framework describes.

VII. Implications

The framework introduced in this paper has implications across three domains that are analytically distinct but structurally connected: organizational governance, retention risk, and workplace policy design. Each domain contains a specific gap that the Tacere framework names and that existing instruments cannot address.

Organizational Governance

The governance gap produced by Tacere is not visible in standard organizational risk assessment because the risk is disclosure-dependent. Leadership capacity erodes, performance continuity degrades, and when departure eventually comes it is recorded as voluntary and personal. The organization loses assets it did not know it was at risk of losing because the risk never generated a signal within any system responsible for detecting it.

This has direct implications for board-level oversight of leadership continuity and succession planning. Governance frameworks require that material risks to organizational performance be identified, assessed, and managed. A risk that is structurally invisible to the measurement systems responsible for detecting it is not a managed risk. It is an unclassified one. The departure of a senior leader following years of sustained high performance, without prior accommodation requests, without clinical engagement that produced an organizational record, and without any disclosed condition, does not register as a governance failure under current frameworks because the collection condition was never met and no data point was ever generated.

Tacere provides the classification that makes this risk legible. The organization has no succession plan for a departure it cannot anticipate, because the conditions producing it were never disclosed. The executive the board considers a stable leadership asset is, in

fact, a continuity risk; contingent on conditions the organization has not measured, shaped by a calculation it has not been party to, and capable of resolving at any time in an unanticipated vacancy. That is a governance exposure. Naming it as such is the first requirement for managing it.

The implication is not that organizations should require disclosure. It is that governance frameworks should account for the structural condition that makes the disclosed population an incomplete representation of the at-risk population. The gap between what the organization can see, and what is actually present in the workforce, is not a measurement problem that better data collection will close.

Retention Risk

Standard retention and attrition instruments are calibrated to detect the behavioral signals that precede voluntary departure in the general workforce population. Declining engagement, reduced performance, increased absenteeism, and manager relationship deterioration are the dominant predictive indicators. Those instruments function correctly for the population they were designed to detect. They do not function, however, for the senior executive whose departure is preceded by none of those signals because the practice of Tacere has kept the conditions that are producing the departure invisible to the systems responsible for detecting risk.

The exit data for a woman who has practiced Tacere across a multi-year tenure will show full performance until departure. The exit interview, if one occurs, will record a stated reason that reflects her disclosure decision, not her full condition. The retention instrument will not flag the departure as anomalous because the performance record provided no prior signal of risk. The cost of the departure, typically estimated at one to two times annual compensation for senior roles and significantly higher for roles that carry institutional knowledge and client relationships, will be absorbed without a causal record that would enable organizational learning or systemic response.

The implication is not a better measurement instrument. Standard retention instruments were not designed for this population and recalibrating them still requires something from her she has already decided not to give. The implication is architectural. The response infrastructure must be built to function without her data, without her signal, and without her disclosure. The gap in the record is not the problem to solve. It is the condition to design around.

Workplace Policy Design

The legislative and policy response to menopause, chronic illness, and caregiver status in the workplace has accelerated significantly across state and federal jurisdictions since 2024. The policy design in every jurisdiction examined shares the foundational architecture this paper has documented in the accommodation law literature: protection activates when disclosure occurs. The law provides the right. The individual must invoke it. The system responds when the record exists.

The population most affected by menopause, chronic illness, and caregiver status in professional environments is not randomly distributed across the disclosure spectrum. It is disproportionately concentrated in the population for whom disclosure carries the highest professional cost: senior women in hierarchical and competitive environments where visibility as someone whose authority may be in question carries real professional consequence, and Black women in those same environments for whom the historical cost structure compounds that consequence further.

The legislation being enacted — menopause accommodations, chronic illness protections, caregiver status provisions — reaches the women who can afford to invoke it. However, the implication is that the policy design, by requiring disclosure as the initiating condition, structurally confirms the gap it was designed to close. The women most likely to need these protections are the least likely to invoke them. The data generated by mandated studies will reflect only the disclosed population, not the full population. The resulting conclusions will be systematically incomplete in ways the legislation cannot correct, because both the measurement instrument and the protection mechanism depend on the same disclosure condition this paper identifies as the structural gap.

Policy design that accounts for Tacere requires a different approach: not the elimination of disclosure-based protections, which serve the population that can afford to use them, but the parallel development of disclosure-independent support infrastructure that reaches the population that cannot. The two are not in competition. They address different populations operating under different cost structures in the same professional environments. Both are necessary, only one currently exists.

The claim that the population most affected by these conditions is least likely to engage with the disclosure pathways such legislation requires is not an assertion. It is documented.

The Michigan Women's Commission Menopause Memorandum (2025) is the most robust state-level dataset on menopause and work in the United States: thirteen statewide conversations, more than 2,500 women engaged, 652 survey responses, seven pieces of legislation, and endorsement from Governor Gretchen Whitmer. The need was documented, the demand for support was documented and the knowledge gap was documented. Yet the central pattern remains: **fewer than one in five women disclosed their menopause status at work**. Thirty percent were not comfortable discussing symptoms for fear of judgment, 26 percent would feel embarrassed raising the issue with colleagues, and 52 percent reported that workplace culture did not support taking time off for menopause-related symptoms. Only 12 percent were confident they knew where to seek help, and just 8 percent expressed satisfaction with available resources.

These are women who had access to a system Michigan was building in real time, and had already made a decision about what was safe to say, to whom, and inside which systems. The Maven Clinic data corroborates the pattern nationally: 44% of millennial and 34% of Gen X women experiencing menopause avoided discussing symptoms at work due to fear of professional stigma (Maven Clinic, 2024). The Bonafide longitudinal survey found that 48% of women believed menopausal women are seen as less productive or emotionally stable in the workplace (Bonafide Health, 2024).

The Korn Ferry Institute and Vira Health global survey of more than 8,000 women corroborates the pattern at scale. Only 42% had spoken with their line manager about their experiences. Only 37% had spoken with HR. Only 27% had spoken with senior leadership. The majority did not talk and were not willing to talk with the people managing them. For the population this framework describes, the cost is not hypothetical. Senior executives reported that menopause symptoms had more than twice the effect on promotions compared to individual contributors, almost three times the effect on selection and hiring for a role, and more than three times the effect on bonuses. The Korn Ferry data confirms the cost structure: the more senior the role, the greater the documented impact of disclosure on promotions, hiring decisions, and compensation.

The LiveCareer Working Through Menopause Report (2025), surveying nearly 900 employed women in the United States, confirms the pattern at the individual level. Ninety-seven percent reported feeling pressured to hide or downplay their symptoms at work. Among those who chose not to speak about menopause at work, 61% cited company culture as the reason, 61% feared being judged, and 18% said they did not

trust HR. Critically, 91% of women begin experiencing symptoms before age 50, the same period many step into senior management and leadership roles. The timing compounds the cost: the years when disclosure carries the highest professional risk are the same years when the physiological condition is most likely to be present. That 97% felt pressured to conceal it is not evidence of a psychological safety gap. It is evidence that the calculation the framework describes is operating at scale.

Taken together, these data sources confirm the paper's central thesis: the population this framework describes does not fail to engage with available support because it lacks access, information, or legal protection. It has assessed those conditions, including the very conditions these studies were designed to improve, and made a different decision. The disclosure requirement embedded in every protection mechanism is the same condition that produces Tacere. Policy design flows into law, and because it is built on disclosed data, those laws are shaped by the minority willing to disclose. Policy that does not account for that decision will continue to measure and serve only the population that discloses, leaving those who have already chosen not to raise their hand outside the architecture. The infrastructure must be built for both.

VIII. Limitations

This paper is conceptual and advances a classification framework rather than an empirical test of the phenomena it describes. The claims advanced here are therefore structural and analytical, not statistical, and do not assert that all instances of non-disclosure reflect the practice defined as Tacere.

The framework is intentionally bounded to a specific population: senior executives operating in professional environments where the cost of visibility carries organizational and career consequences and concealment is viable. For the purposes of this framework, senior executives are understood as those whose productivity, output quality, and consistent ability to exceed organizational expectations place them among the elite contributors within their organizations, individuals whose professional standing is validated through performance reviews, compensation trajectory, and the informal authority structures that govern advancement. Within that boundary, the paper argues that sustained non-disclosure may reflect a rational governance decision, while recognizing that non-disclosure in other contexts may arise from different mechanisms, including misperception, stigma, or constraint.

The focus on senior executives reflects the population for whom the incentive and opportunity conditions that produce Tacere are most pronounced, not an assertion that the conditions are exclusive to that population. Mid-level managers operating in environments where disclosure carries professional cost and concealment remains viable may practice Tacere under the same structural logic. The ability to maintain non-disclosure narrows as organizational visibility increases, which is why the framework's boundary is anchored at the senior executive level while remaining open to empirical examination across the broader organizational hierarchy.

The distinction between Tacere and adjacent constructs is established at the level of definition and mechanism. Empirical validation and boundary condition testing are necessary next steps for future research.

Tacere is not directly measurable at the individual level without violating its defining constraint, which is the absence of disclosure and the non-generation of a record. The framework is structurally inferable rather than individually observable, and future empirical work should be designed accordingly.

The intersectional claim advanced in Section V similarly operates at the level of structural analysis, arguing that for Black and African American women the cost structure of visibility is a foundational condition of the decision environment rather than an adjustment applied to a mechanism that works the same way for everyone. This claim is grounded in prior literature documenting the historical cost structure of visibility for Black women in professional environments and in the structural reasoning developed across Sections IV and V, but requires empirical examination across contexts and populations to assess its generalizability.

Finally, the response architecture introduced in Section VI is presented as a conceptual design constraint rather than an operational model. The paper does not specify implementation, effectiveness, or comparative outcomes. These limitations do not weaken the classification advanced here, but they do define the scope within which its claims should be interpreted and the directions in which the framework can be further developed.

IX. Conclusion

This paper has introduced Tacere as a conceptual framework naming a condition that existing organizational behavior, labor economics, and employment law literatures have not classified as a subject of study in its own right. The sustained, strategic practice of keeping one's own counsel by a senior executive operating in a professional environment where disclosure carries professional risk is not a failure condition. It is not a gap in psychological safety, a deficit of legal literacy, or an absence of organizational support. It is a governance decision produced by a structural incentive and opportunity system that makes transparency costly and concealment rational. The contribution of this paper is classification. The condition has been present in the professional lives of women, particularly Black and African American women in professional environments, long before this paper named it. Naming it is the first requirement for addressing it.

The paper has established four analytical claims. First, that the existing literature's treatment of non-disclosure as a failure condition is structurally incomplete because it does not account for the individual who has accurately assessed the available conditions and determined that disclosure remains professionally untenable. Second, that Tacere is a distinct practice, not reducible to *impression management*, *identity concealment*, *covering*, *coping*, or *strategic ambiguity*, because it operates prior to and independently of any organizational relationship and does not require an audience, a stigmatized identity, or a distress state as preconditions. Third, that the incentive and opportunity structure of professional environments produces Tacere as a predictable outcome without requiring organizational intent, and that this structural condition persists regardless of whether the individual discloses. Fourth, for Black women in professional environments, the cost structure of visibility is historically documented, structurally compounded, and not symmetrical with the cost experienced by other populations, making race a foundational condition of the framework rather than a moderating variable.

These claims have implications for organizational governance, retention risk, and workplace policy design that the paper has examined in Section VII. The common thread across all three domains is the same: the gap between what existing frameworks can see and what is actually present in the workforce is not a measurement problem that better data collection will close. The Power User TrapSM is the mechanism by which that gap becomes a governance exposure: the executive whose performance record signals stability is the executive whose departure the organization will not have predicted and cannot explain.

This paper is the individual behavioral complement to the companion framework, Invisible AttritionSM: A Conceptual Framework for Leadership Capacity Erosion Prior to Organizational Detection. That framework addresses what the organization cannot see. This paper addresses why the individual decided not to disclose. Together they propose that the structural condition is legible, nameable, and addressable from two positions simultaneously: the individual who has made the governance decision, and the organization that has no architecture designed to reach her without requiring her to disclose. The two frameworks share a governing logic: systems do not require intent. They require incentive and opportunity. Classification is the precondition for infrastructure design. Infrastructure design is the precondition for reach. Neither paper resolves the structural condition. Both establish that it can be named, which is where the work of resolution begins. Tacere is not the absence of analysis. It is the product of it.

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